

THE REAL DEAL Alphonso-seller at Crawford Market, Mumbai

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Pulp Friction

Alphonso mangoes are caught in a GI showdown between Maharashtra's Konkan and Gujarat's Valsad growers

By **Dhaval S. Kulkarni and Jumana Shah**

WHAT MAKES AN ALPHONSO MANGO TRULY ALPHONSO—its variety, its geography or its history? The question lies at the heart of a dispute between growers in Maharashtra and Gujarat, after a bid to secure a GI (Geographical Indication) tag—a legal label that protects products linked to a specific place—for the Valsad Hapus (Hapus is an alternative name for Alphonso) challenged the exclusivity long claimed by the Konkan's famed fruit. Alphonso derives its name from the 16th-century Portuguese general Afonso de Albuquerque.

In 2018, Alphonso received GI status limited to five coastal districts of Maharashtra—Sindhudurg, Ratnagiri, Raigad, Thane and Palghar. Growers describe the tag as recognition of the region's laterite soil, humidity, flowering cycles and centuries of cultivation that shape the fruit's taste.

In 2022, the Bharatiya Kisan Sangh (BKS), backed by Navsari Agricultural University, applied for a GI tag for Valsad Hapus. After hearings, growers from the Konkan objected in October 2025. "We are against the move as the mangoes grown in the Konkan are the real Hapus. The Hapus mango is not grown in Valsad. The cultivators there can call it a mango if they wish, but not Hapus," said Ajit Gogate, former MLA and chairman of the Devgad Taluka Amba Utpadak Sahakari Sanstha Maryadit, urging the Maharashtra government to intervene.

Konkan growers allege that mangoes from Karnataka and Gujarat are often misbranded and sold as Ratnagiri or Devgad Alphonso, with cheaper fruit mixed into Alphonso pulp products. "We do not want the Alphonso tag to become generic," says Dr Vivek Bhide, president of the Konkan Hapus Amba Utpadak Ani Utpadak Vikrete Sahkari Sanstha, Ratnagiri. "That harms the idea."

Takeaways

- **Mango growers clash over Alphonso's heritage, trade and authenticity**
- **Political rhetoric intensifies as parties frame the GI fight as regional stakes**

Legal experts advocate a more nuanced reading of GI law. Lawyer Ganesh Hingmire argues Maharashtra should have sought separate GIs, such as Ratnagiri Alphonso and Devgad Alphonso. He cites the Gir Kesar and Marathwada Kesar, both of which have individual GI status. "Hapus is a variety," he says. That reasoning underpins Gujarat farmers' defence. They argue that Alphonso is a varietal name, while GI law hinges on geography.

"The prefix is the clincher," says the farmer, advocating region-specific tags. He adds that flowering seasons do not overlap and, with a shelf life of two to three weeks, Valsad mangoes cannot dent Konkan's market window. "Exports from both states are handled by traders based in Maharashtra. This is a marketing issue."

FRUIT OF CONTENTION

The dispute has now taken on political overtones in Maharashtra, with leaders of the Opposition Maha Vikas Aghadi saying the GI claim reflects a broader pattern of the BJP-ruled Gujarat staking a claim to their state's assets, material as well as symbolic. The BJP-led ruling alliance has been more measured. Fisheries minister Nitesh Rane has said Konkan MPs will take up the issue with the Centre, and industries minister Uday Samant has downplayed fears, saying the reputation of Ratnagiri and Devgad Alphonso will endure.

"The sweet taste of our mangoes will persist," he says. Amid the rhetoric, the BKS maintains that farmers are being pitted against each other. "We do not want to fight our brothers," says BKS general secretary R.K. Patel. A mango by any name would taste as sweet. ■